

THE CLUTCH

EXPEDITION TO BARRIER PEAKS



ISSUE 6

The party spends the night on Level Six under the watch of the Shadu — enormous winged beings they negotiated with the night before.



The party departs. The Shadu resume scheduled beard maintenance.



The robot room contains a caged armored creature and two enormous worker robots — far larger than anything the party has faced before.



RECAP:
Snivel rolls a grenade through the robot's legs. The explosion damages the machines — but doesn't stop them.



Cornered by eleven robots, the party retreats to the Shadu room. Willa asks for help. The corridor outside fills with machines. And the Shadu consider.



The corridor had not gotten smaller. It only felt that way.

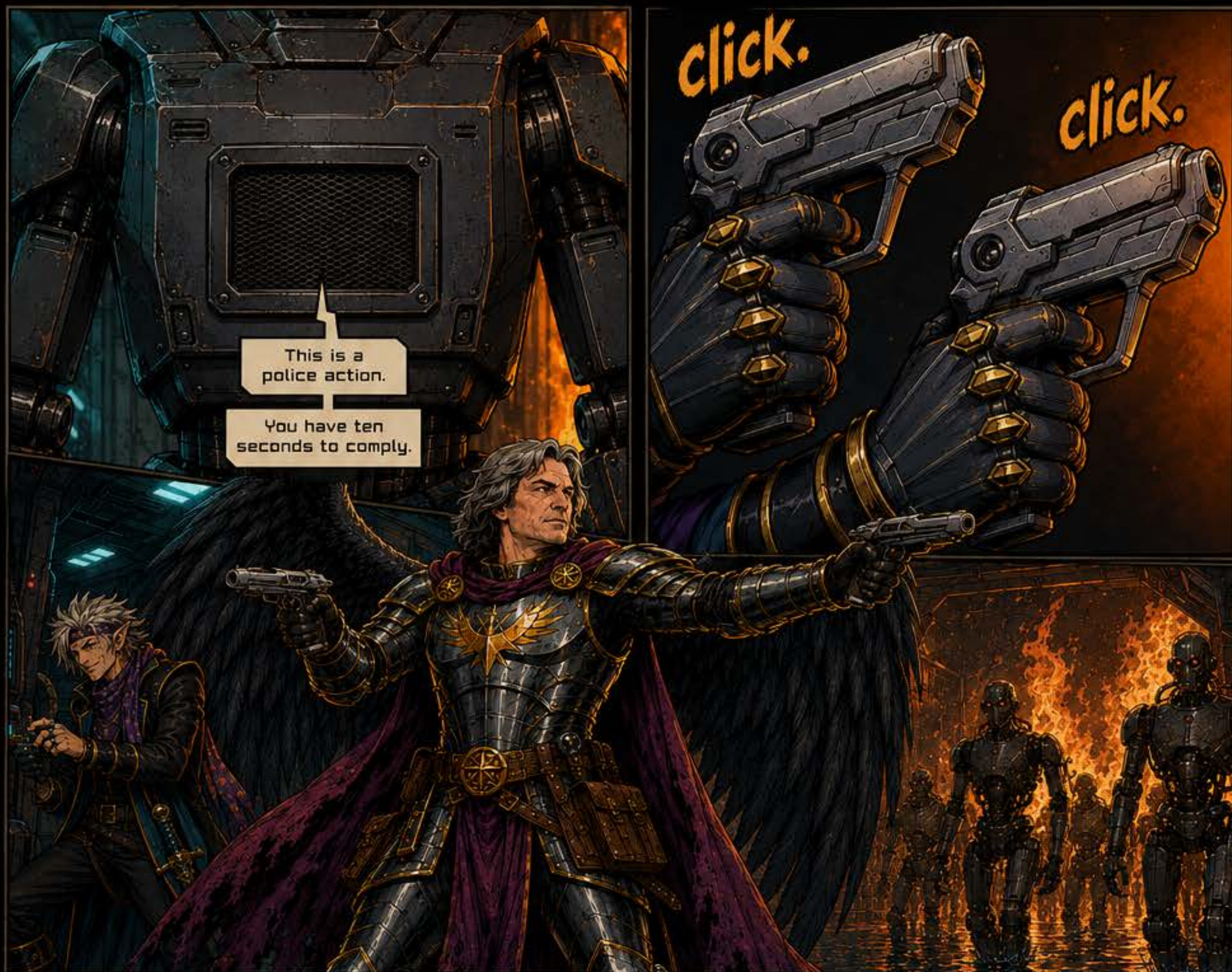


This is a police action.

You have ten seconds to comply.

click.

click.



WYATT.
I NEED SOMETHING
FROM YOU
RIGHT NOW.

WORKING
ON IT.



The nearest worker robot opened a small panel in its side.



He felt himself yanked forward across the deck plating — not falling, not stumbling, but pulled, magnetically, like a coin drawn to a lodestone.



Oh.

That's what that does.

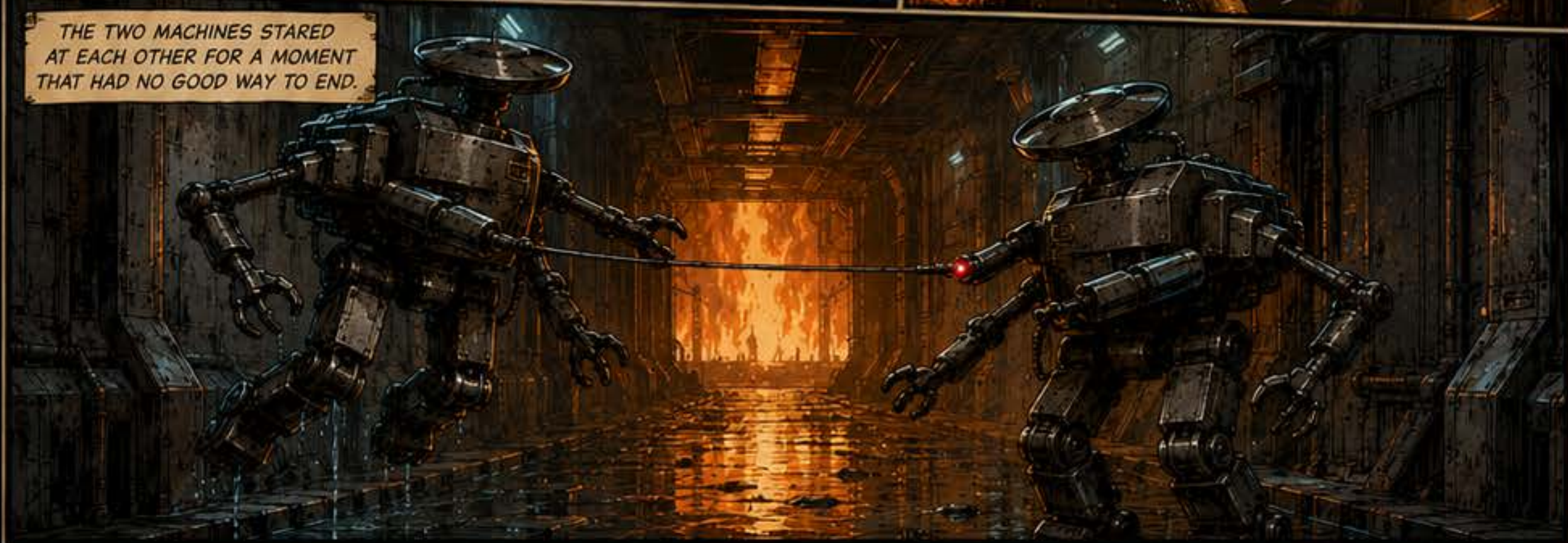


And Mickey has to clean up.

A second beam fired.



THE TWO MACHINES STARED AT EACH OTHER FOR A MOMENT THAT HAD NO GOOD WAY TO END.



THE TWO MACHINES STARED
AT EACH OTHER FOR A MOMENT
THAT HAD NO GOOD WAY TO END.

CLANK

THE GROUNDED ROBOT MADE
A CHECK, AND FAILED ANYWAY,
AND BOTH OF THEM WENT OVER.

Tom Jones was
already praying.

Forty-four gallons of
water, specifically, created
directly above the robot
that was holding Mickey,
created now.

CRASH—

Its grip
loosened.

Mickey wriggled. Mickey, who had recently been soaped down in preparation for exactly this kind of situation, poured out of the robot's arms like water through a fist and hit the deck on all four feet.



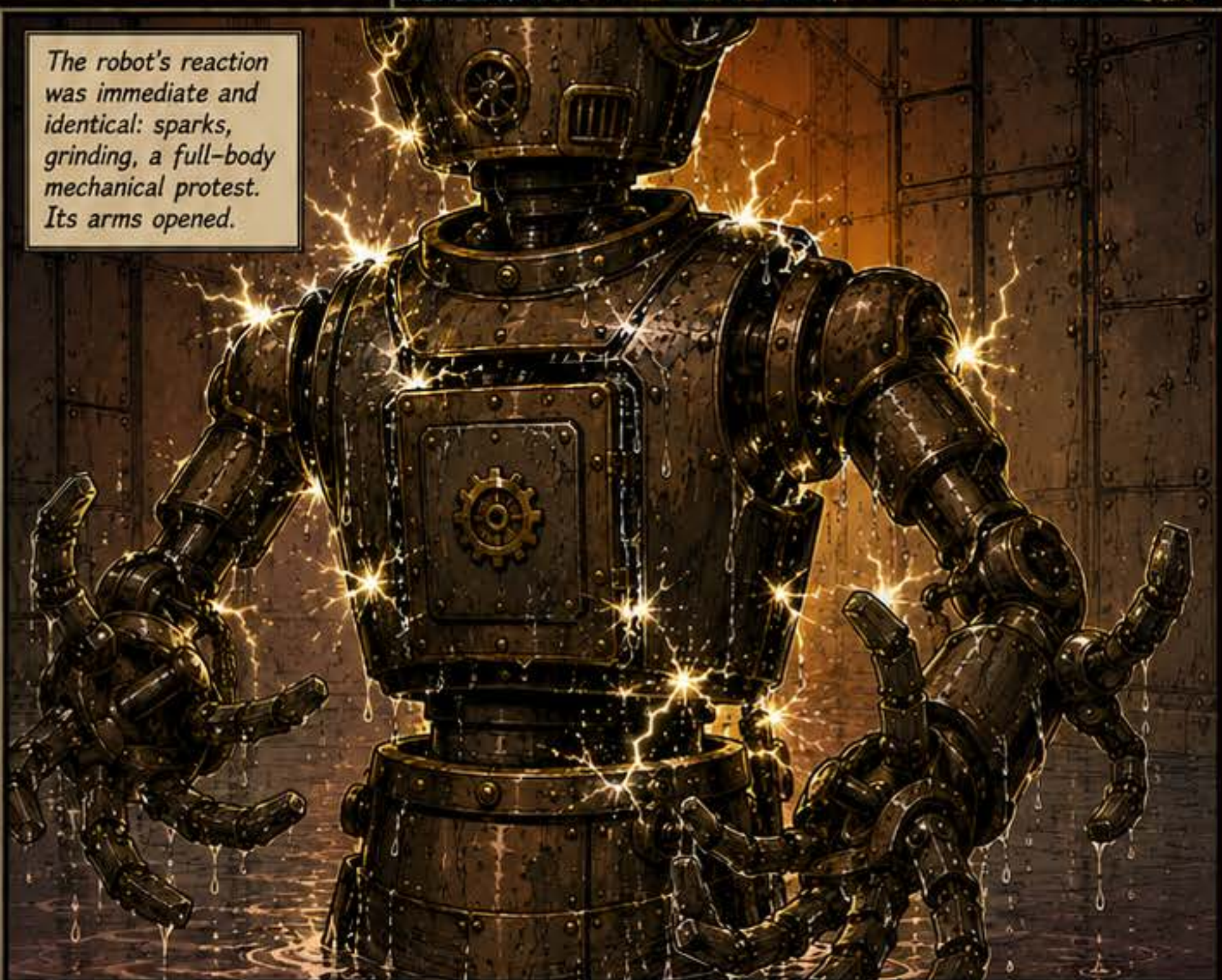
DerDer ErDer, reading the situation with the efficiency of a man who had been casting the same spell all morning and was getting very good at it—



Rosewater, specifically.



The robot's reaction was immediate and identical: sparks, grinding, a full-body mechanical protest. Its arms opened.



For two seconds the party could see exactly where he was.



That's the best you've smelled in weeks.



Wyatt ran.

Not retreating —
running, which is
a different thing,
a thing with more
velocity and less
dignity and
considerably better
survival statistics.



WHOOOM



THE WATER ON THE
GROUND BECAME STEAM
IN APPROXIMATELY
ONE SECOND.

THE STEAM BECAME
EVERYTHING.

GO.
EVERYBODY GO.
I'VE GOT
THIS END.

I'VE GOT
THE END.

YOU'VE GOT
AN EMPTY CORRIDOR
AND A WALL
OF FIRE.



One of the remaining robots pressed through the wall anyway.



DerDer ErDer stepped aside with the specific nonchalance of a man who had just done something impressive and was pretending it had been easy.



Alfie cast the wall of ice.



It froze exactly as it was — one arm extended, one foot raised — suspended in the ice with the permanent, dignified paralysis of something that had been in exactly the wrong place when the spell landed.



Han Solo.



They turned and ran for the violet card door, and the corridor behind them was a wall of fire and a wall of ice and two broken robots cooling on the floor and one robot frozen mid-stride—



--AND SOMEWHERE BEYOND ALL OF IT, FIVE POLICE UNITS THAT WERE GOING TO HAVE A VERY BAD MORNING ONCE THE FIRE BURNED DOWN.



Wrong turn.
Totally fine.
Don't mind us.



*He knew they
couldn't see it.*



He did it anyway.

Gary and Sean
were playing cards.

This was the detail
that landed first —
not the wings, not the
scale of them.

I RAISE.



Wyatt stopped.

He had been turning
something over
since the corridor.



Do you
know anything
about the Rod of
Seven Parts?

THE CARDS
DISAPPEARED.

NOT DROPPED —
DISAPPEARED,
BETWEEN ONE
MOMENT AND THE NEXT.

ARE YOU
HUMAN?

SPEAK TRUTHFULLY,
HALF-ELF. TELL ME
WHAT YOU KNOW
OF THIS.





We've found pieces of it. Other things want it badly.

Nobody we've asked could tell us anything useful. We're hoping what it carries might matter — further in.



The rod had not always been called the Rod of Seven Parts.

It had been forged in another dimension. Not made, not crafted — assembled from the combined power of beings that sat somewhere between gods and the older things that gods replaced.



One of them could not be stopped. The others gathered what they had and poured it into a weapon and gave it to a chosen one and sent them in.

Both of them fell.



We have two pieces.

Both Shadu visibly relaxed.

It was a small movement — a loosening in the enormous wings, a settling of weight — but it was there.

Find the exits.



Always find the exits.

How do you activate them?



EACH PIECE HAS ITS OWN ACTIVATION. EACH HAS NATIVE POWERS WITHIN IT. TWO PIECES NEAR EACH OTHER AMPLIFY THOSE POWERS BY ORDERS OF MAGNITUDE.

THE ROD, FULLY ASSEMBLED, WOULD BE SOMETHING THAT NO MEMBER OF THIS PARTY IS CURRENTLY EQUIPPED TO SURVIVE, LET ALONE WIELD.



Then how do I deactivate them?



Deactivating is considerably more difficult than activating.



Tom Jones reached into the bag of holding with both arms, almost to the shoulder.



HE HELD IT FLAT
ON HIS PALMS,
NOT OFFERING —
PRESENTING.

THE SHADU
LOOKED AT IT,
AND THEN THE
PIECE LIFTED.

TOM JONES FELT
NO INCLINATION
TO RESIST.

The party could see —
even those with no frame
of reference — that these
two were not the ends of
anything.

They were
middle sections.

And the space around
them — the space where
the other five pieces
would go — was empty
in a way that had
the shape of an absence.

What would you
want for them?
Hypothetically.
Like — what's
the number?

WE'RE ON
A MISSION
FROM GOD.

SOMETHING
LIKE THAT.

THERE IS NOT
ENOUGH GOLD ON THE
EARTH TO OPEN THE
CONVERSATION. AND
WE DON'T WANT THE
PIECES.

We have
sensed the mind
flayer. It has moved. It
is no longer where we
told you it was.

From its
previous position,
it has gone
southward.

Southward.

Right.
Let's go.

BEFORE THEY LEFT THE SHADU ROOM, WYATT HEARD IT.

THE PARTICULAR SOUND OF SEVERAL HUNDRED POUNDS OF ICE HITTING A DECK FLOOR ALL AT ONCE.

NOT A VOICE — A SOUND, LOW AND SPECIFIC, THE KIND OF THING THAT ONLY RESOLVED INTO MEANING ONCE YOU KNEW WHAT YOU WERE LISTENING FOR.

CRASH

THE WALL OF ICE WAS DOWN.

We have to go. Now.

The robots that held you here — they're coming through. We're heading north.

Hmmm —
H
M
M
M
M
!

The door began to glow in response.

Thank you for the warning. Good luck on your quest.

Right. Good talk.

The next cargo hold was large and dim and smelled of nothing in particular, which was a change.



Then Wyatt heard the thumping.

Soft impacts, irregular, in groupings that didn't quite resolve into a pattern. Not metal against metal — something duller, a little muffled.



He signed to Snivel. Snivel signed back.



Around the bend. North and left. Maybe fifty feet.

Alfie, invisible, was already walking in that direction.



IT HAD BEEN TRYING TO
FREE ITSELF – THE SAME
SEQUENCE OF MOVEMENTS,
OVER AND OVER, THE SAME
ARM GOING TO THE SAME
PIECE OF DEBRIS, THE SAME
FAILURE, THE SAME RESET.

IT HAD BEEN
DOING THIS FOR
SOME TIME.

Damsel in
distress. Go save
her.

CLANK!

CLANK!

KLANK!

CLANK!

THE ARMOR DID
WHAT ARMOR DOES.

Please help.

Please help.

Please help.

Snivel watched this from a position
of profound secondhand embarrassment,
mouth closed.

♪ SKREEE – SKPeee – SKPeee – SKPeee... ♪

The scream had
auto-tune on it,
which made it
worse somehow.





Another cargo hold,
longer than the others,
curving slightly south.



Wyatt could hear water
somewhere ahead.



Alfie, invisible and emboldened by both
his invisibility and the recent decapitation
that had not involved him, moved ahead of
the group around a corner of tall crates.

snap.

The snap of the twig had done it — the whole asshole of them lifting off from wherever they'd been roosting above the door.



Alfie fired.



PFWUMP

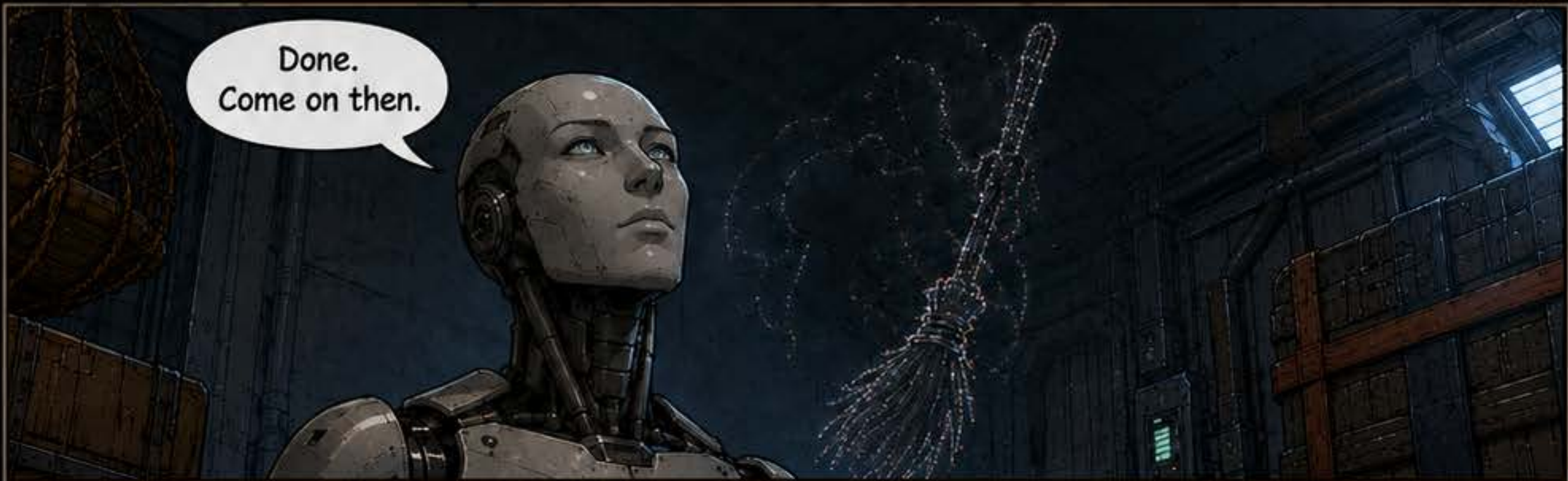


*SMALL.
SPECTACULAR.
STINKING.*

Thank you for the assistance. There are more. I have no payment, but I will continue on your journey with you and help you as I am able throughout your encounters on this level of the ship.



Done.
Come on then.



The gas bats
were already moving.

Their bodies organizing
into the tight diving
formation of things that
had been doing this
longer than the ship had
been crashed.

Alfie cast
the fireball.

Twenty-seven points of heat
moved through the colony
with the thoroughness of a propane
torch introduced to a wasp nest.

FOOM — FOOM FOOM — FOOMFOOMFOOM —

Then silence.

The ceiling was darker
than it had been.
The smell was significant.

Down the corridor, the rest
of the party saw the flashes
through the doorway and
felt the concussions in
their feet.

Somebody said
something.

Nobody moved
toward the sound.

Remember
me?

And Alfie did.



The explosions
were still echoing.



SILENT



The rest of the party
couldn't hear anything else.



Nobody knew where Alfie was.



TO BE CONTINUED...